

Relational Aesthetics: Coauthored Marks and Social Form

Relational Aesthetics: Coauthored Marks and Social Form I

Relational aesthetics frames art as a production of human relations rather than only objects for contemplation [a@bourriaud2002relation]. Bishop's critique is equally important because it warns against treating every engineered encounter as automatically emancipatory or socially meaningful [a@bishop2004antagonism]. PPPiP already had a relational structure: the drawing mattered because it enacted the relationship. The couple joint drawing method gives this point a nearby arts-therapy precedent by treating shared drawing as an expression of connectedness and individuality rather than a finished-image score [a@snir2013joint]. DigiPPPiP makes that ontology explicit in digital form. The artifact is a trace of mutual attention, negotiation, and improvisation; the canvas is a social scene.

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II

Digital-intimacy research sharpens the claim. Technologies for strong-tie relationships often work through awareness, expressivity, physicalness, gift giving, joint action, and memory rather than through high-volume information transfer [Hassenzahl 2012; Vetter 2005]. DigiPPPiP sits closest to joint action and memory: the partners do something together, and the resulting artifact can remain available as a trace. That makes the practice more specific than generic messaging and more cautious than therapeutic promise.

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III

The first-principles relational test is whether the artifact still points back to the other person as an agent. A canvas full of marks is not relational if one partner dominates, if the other cannot perceive or alter the shared field, or if the system substitutes automated novelty for reciprocal response. Relational aesthetics therefore functions as a constraint on design: the scene must leave room for mutual recognition, refusal, repair, and surprise.

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IV

Creative arts therapy research offers a neurodynamic vocabulary for this claim. Aesthetic engagement externalizes affect, supports co-regulation, and creates intersubjective resonance [vaiser2024neurodynamics]. Close-relationship co-regulation scholarship narrows the term: it should mean bidirectional linkage across partners' emotional channels, not a vague feeling of harmony [butler2012coregulation]. Physiological-linkage reviews make the boundary even more conservative because linkage can be helpful, neutral, or risky depending on task, affective context, and overload [timmons2015physiologicallinkage]. Family-level coregulation models add a useful multi-timescale warning: dyadic regulation can be nested inside broader relational systems, so a drawing trace alone cannot prove well-being [paley2022familycoregulation]. Art-making studies also suggest plausible stress and reflection constructs for future measurement [kaimal2016cortisol], while pandemic art-therapy discussions show why remote creative practices need careful ethical framing [potash2020pandemics].